

## Chapter 70\_1: Child

Ning Fuyi had never seen Chu Qingqiu cry like this. She was half-kneeling in the muddy water, her chin drooped to her chest, crying so hard that her palms unconsciously curled up, barely able to hold the few pieces of broken jade.

Ning Fuyi panicked for a moment, her hand extended in mid-air, not knowing what to do. After hesitating by her side for a long time, she finally frantically grabbed her sleeve to wipe the tears from her face.

However, the more she wiped, the more tears flowed. Finally, Ning Fuyi had to give up. She stared fixedly at the top of Chu Qingqiu's head, not knowing why her heart felt both sour and swollen.

"If it's broken, it's broken. I'll buy you another one later. If you don't like other styles, I'll buy raw stones and grind one exactly the same for you, alright?" For the first time, Ning Fuyi softened her voice when speaking to Chu Qingqiu. This feeling was very strange, as if their positions had suddenly undergone a subtle reversal.

"Even if you buy another one, it won't be this one anymore. When jade is broken, it's broken."

Ning Fuyi was speechless. She hadn't expected that a randomly chosen jade bracelet would be treasured by her so much. So she forcibly dug those few pieces of jade from Chu Qingqiu's palm. Those bloodstained hands immediately curled up, cradling them in her palms.

Chu Qingqiu was about to scold her for something when the woman before her suddenly wrapped one arm around her shoulders, applied force with her wrist, and gently pulled her into her embrace. The words in her mouth could no longer be spoken.

Chu Qingqiu sighed, her hands secretly reaching for her sleeves, gripping that fabric tightly.

Then she closed her eyes, letting the tears fall even more fiercely.

After everything ended, the people scattered all over the ground slowly got up. Some were limping, some had exhausted their immortal power, some were gasping for breath from exhaustion. They all looked up at that qilin.

With the auspicious beast's return to the world, wind and rain ceased immediately. The blazing sun hung high overhead, drying the earth that had just been washed by heavy rain.

"My goodness, this is really a qilin? And it's a mature one!" An Eastern Courtyard disciple wiped the muddy water from his face, shocked beyond measure.

"Senior Brother, compared to the Divine Venerable's white tiger, which is more powerful?" that disciple asked Hong Ying beside him.

Hong Ying was also extremely disheveled. While picking up his heavy sword, he said: "Both being ancient divine beasts, how can you tell who's more powerful? It's just that this qilin has lustrous fur all over and a massive body—clearly a mature beast that has cultivated for tens of thousands of years. The Divine Venerable's Bai Lin, though also a divine beast, is just a young beast."

"Then this Ning Fuyi has such good luck! Not only did she get her life back, but she also got an ancient divine beast!" That disciple almost had the word "envy" written all over his face.

"Enough, opportunities don't come to everyone. Don't think about these things. Your senior sister is still lying on the ground—hurry and go heal her!" Hong Ying kicked him and sent him to Feng Ge's side.

The qilin in mid-air slowly stopped its beast roar. Its mountain-sized eyes turned toward the ground, then its body shrank in the brilliant sunlight, finally transforming into a white-haired, golden-eyed woman in red robes, who descended on clouds.

Liu Wenzhu and Rong Jin anxiously ran toward Ning Fuyi, but were stopped by a charming voice: "At this time, you shouldn't go disturb them."

Liu Wenzhu looked toward her upon hearing this. After seeing that face clearly, she gasped in shock, and a thousand-pound hammer immediately appeared in her palm: "You are..."

"It's me." Jiuying placed her slender finger on her lips in a silencing gesture, her eyes flowing like water. "Where's that loud, foolish girl of yours?"

"What loud, foolish girl..." Liu Wenzhu glanced at Rong Jin, then realized, "Qiu Yi? She, she's still at the sect, didn't come with us."

"Oh~" Jiuying nodded.

Several people looked toward the two figures in the distance, obscured by weeds and unclear. They couldn't see their movements, only glimpses of red and white clothing.

"The Divine Venerable..." Liu Wenzhu said softly, "seems very worried about Yiyi. I've never seen her so lost and distraught."

"Yes, it seems so. She was really frightened," Rong Jin said quietly.

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Fortunately, this battle didn't result in too many casualties. Only a few Eastern Courtyard disciples suffered minor injuries. Thanks to Jiuying's blessing, when she was reborn from fire, she burned most of the vengeful spirits, preventing a disaster of vengeful spirits wreaking havoc on the world. The rest were also subdued and prepared to be sent to the underworld.

After all affairs were handled, everyone embarked on their journey back to the sect. As evening approached, half of the azure sky was covered with step-like sunset clouds. The vast sky was broad and distant, making one feel refreshed when gazing into the distance.

Li Zhao'an's corpse was placed in the furthest corner. The disciples huddled together guarding the wounded, exhaustedly falling into dreams. Elder Pingyao stood with Chu Qingqiu on the tiger's head, discussing something.

Chu Qingqiu no longer showed any traces of having cried. Only her eyes and nose tip were still somewhat red, covered by the twilight's heavenly light. She stood with her hands behind her back beneath the firmament, her expression stern.

"I never expected that demon clan monsters could break into our Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. I don't know what they're plotting, to actually target an ordinary disciple. After returning to the sect, we must strengthen the barriers to prevent such incidents from happening again." Elder Pingyao said in a heavy voice.

Chu Qingqiu shook her head lightly: "Elder Pingyao, don't you think this incident came too coincidentally? That demon clan member was targeting Ning Fuyi. If it was an outsider demon, how would he happen to choose Li Zhao'an?"

Elder Pingyao took a deep breath upon hearing this, frowning: "The Divine Venerable means this person is from our mountain gate?"

"This venerable is only guessing, especially since both Ning Fuyi and I felt that person was familiar when we were at Zhaoyao Mountain. But it's also possible that this person has many spies and was monitoring Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. Whether it's planted spies or this person mixed in among us, we must be careful going forward."

"Someone from within the sect..." Elder Pingyao fell into deep thought. "Does the Divine Venerable have anyone in mind as a suspect? Could it be Mei..."

"Mei Chengshu is indeed worth suspecting, but precisely because he's so suspicious, he's actually less likely to be the one." Chu Qingqiu said indifferently.

Elder Pingyao nodded. She sighed: "Ever since the former sect master passed away, our Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate and even the five realms have been unstable. I hope we can survive this tribulation."

Chu Qingqiu said nothing more, her eyelashes drooping to cover her eyes that were somewhat red from being washed by tears.

Behind her, a pair of eyes stared at her intently until they were interrupted by a woman who had returned from soaring through the sky. Only then did Ning Fuyi blink and withdraw her gaze.

Earlier, Chu Qingqiu had cried like a flood in her arms, but after people came, she turned and left as if the person who had sobbed in her embrace was someone else.

It felt like someone tickling her heart with a feather, making it itch, then pulling the feather away—truly irresponsible.

Ning Fuyi didn't know where she got the courage to hold her, but the best way to comfort a crying person was through embraces. She had done just that, and it seemed indeed effective. At least the Chu Qingqiu held in her arms had stopped trembling.

And she hadn't been beaten either.

Slender fingers painted with rouge waved in front of her eyes, forcing her gaze back. Ning Fuyi glanced sideways at Jiuying, who then withdrew her hand, smiling with curved eyes.

"You've grown a whole circle, but your way of looking at people has become frightening too. It really makes my heart panic." Jiuying placed her finger on her own arm.

"I'm naturally not likeable-looking. I wasn't glaring at you," Ning Fuyi said. "But aren't you a divine beast? Why do you still need to ride on another divine beast?"

"I'm a divine beast that has taken human form. How can I compare to this uncivilized little cub?" Jiuying stepped on Bai Lin's back with her foot. "Thanks to you, I also have the honor of riding a mount once."

"Let's be clear—I saved you because I saw your sincere heart and felt compassion. Don't really treat me as your spirit pet." The woman arranged her hair. "I, Qilin Jiuying, have lived for tens of thousands of years. I wouldn't stoop to being a pet for a young girl. You're not allowed to ride me."

"Don't worry." Ning Fuyi was amused. "I haven't even thanked you for saving my life yet. Why would I ride you?"

"No need to thank me. Being reborn from fire is naturally my clan's talent. Forming a contract with you actually dispersed the demonic energy from my body, which is also a good thing for me. I didn't expect you, a girl with mediocre aptitude, to have some special qualities." Jiuying said.

"It's just that this cultivation level is truly a bit low, suppressing the divine power in my body." Jiuying spoke sarcastically.

"..."

After forming a contract, the power of spirit beasts would be affected by their master's cultivation level. Only now did Ning Fuyi remember to circulate her energy and examine the immortal power in her body. She found it had become more abundant again. It seemed that forming a contract with a divine beast did have certain benefits.

This experience was truly dangerous, Ning Fuyi thought to herself.

Ning Fuyi no longer looked at Chu Qingqiu, but forcibly moved her gaze to the clustered disciples. Liu Wenzhu and Rong Jin were busily applying medicine to the injured disciples.

Not wanting her thoughts to remain chaotic, Ning Fuyi actively looked for conversation topics and asked Jiuying: "Do you have children?"

Jiuying was silent for a moment, then opened her mouth to scold: "This old lady has been alone for tens of thousands of years. Where would children come from? Are you out of your mind..."

"Then why did you stop your killing when you heard Ping'an call out 'mama' that day in the Ghost Eye?" Ning Fuyi quickly interrupted her spell-casting.

Jiuying was stunned, her beautiful eyebrows knitting together. Seeing that she had forgotten, Ning Fuyi recounted the process of fighting with her when she was still a demon beast in the Ghost Eye that day.

"Your stupid dog... Ping'an," Jiuying's eyebrows knitted tighter and tighter, "does it have the aura of a divine beast?"

"No." Ning Fuyi shook her head. "It doesn't even have the aura of a spirit beast, which is why I found it strange."

Jiuying's expression was complex—neither joy nor anger could be discerned. After a long while, she said: "Do you know that birds lay eggs at regular intervals?"

Ning Fuyi nodded.

"The qilin clan, before cultivating human form, is the same. Every five thousand years, they leave behind a qilin egg. However, most eggs laid by unmated qilins are empty shells. Only a very few might be normal eggs."

This matter was somewhat absurd. Even Ning Fuyi fell silent this time. After a long while, she continued: "You're saying Ping'an might have hatched from your egg? A dog?"

"Not a dog—a qilin cub." Jiuying corrected. "However, cubs hatched this way cannot cultivate and are not divine beasts. They just live much longer than ordinary animals."

"I'm suddenly quite expectant about what my cub might look like." Jiuying twirled the hair falling over her shoulder, smiling sweetly.

"You'd better not get your hopes up." Ning Fuyi said with difficulty. "It's a bit fat."